

If you post pictures of your child, you are making a big mistake.

Ella explains it to you.

The images you put on social networks are much more than a memory.

The video that every parent should watch.

Intervention by Guido Scorza, member of the Guarantor for the protection of personal data  
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75% of parents share images and data of their children on social media. Eight out of ten parents are followed on their social media by people they know and by people they have never met. This is how a video from Telekom, one of the largest telecommunications operators in Germany, begins—but this matters little or perhaps nothing because its content does not concern a product or a commercial service—everyone, as parents, should watch and rewatch it.

The story told in the video is that of Ella, a 9-year-old girl, whose parents belong to that 75% who used to share photos, videos, and data of their children online, innocent moments and scenes of lived life, perhaps simple memories. Ella's parents do this, like millions of others, lightly and without ever thinking about the impact that such an act could have on their daughter's future. One day—and this is the heart of the video—someone, through an artificial intelligence solution that is now accessible to everyone for just a few dollars a month, modifies the photos and images of Ella published by her parents until they produce an adult digital twin, who suddenly appears on the cinema screen where the parents have just sat down and tells them what she could not understand and say as a child.

“Hey mom, hey dad, it’s me Ella or, better, a digital version of me, just bigger. Incredible what technology can do today simply starting from a few images, those that you have shared on social media and that can be taken and used by anyone. I know, for you, these photographs are just memories but for others, they are data and for me, perhaps, the beginning of a horrible future, a future in which my identity could be stolen, in which I could go to prison for something I never did, imagine my voice being copied to scam you mom, I don’t want to become a meme humiliated by everyone at school, and certainly, I don’t want this [note: the photo of a naked girl running on a beach renamed “sexy\_girl\_on\_beach” appears on the screen]. What you share online is like a digital footprint that will follow me for the rest of my life. I’m telling you this because I know you love me and that you would never do anything to harm me. So, please mom, please dad, protect my privacy in the digital realm.”

The video then closes by reminding us that the privacy of our children needs special protection and that their safety starts with all of us. It is almost unnecessary to add more words to those measured, thoughtful, effective ones that represent the plot of the video, almost unnecessary to remember how paradoxical it is that we parents, who should be more than anyone else concerned about protecting our children and ensuring them the best possible future, often—truly too often—unintentionally, are the source of their misfortunes in the digital realm.

It is almost unnecessary to remember how heavy, dangerous, and indelible the mortgage we take out on their future is when we publish their photos, their videos, their data on social networks and how little it matters that, even if with enormous superficiality, we often do so with love and pride to tell the world the good we want for them.

The discussion is different for those who consciously and in vain and empty attempts to give themselves and their children a bit of digital popularity literally sell—and sometimes undervalue—their personal identity, image, and data in the baby influencer market.

It is a mistake as a parent to contest or criticize the educational decisions of other parents but, at the same time, it is a mistake to miss the opportunity to remember how valuable what we give up is and what we impose on our children to give up and how infinitely less valuable what is perhaps—anyway, in an insignificant percentage of cases compared to the many who try—what is gained in terms of popularity and money.

Let’s watch the video, let’s rewatch it, let’s listen to Ella’s words and, perhaps, let’s ask our children what they think.